In order to assess students' skills, literary debates were organised. Students at an advanced stage of learning guided younger students. A system of peer learning was also practiced, like you have group/peer work.

Ancient Education System in India: A Way of Life



Gurukula System

In ancient India, both formal and informal education existed. Indigenous education was imparted at home, in temples, patashalas, and gurukulas. There were people in homes, villages and temples who guided young children in imbibing pious ways of life. Temples played a vital role in imparting education and served the centres of learning. Students went to viharas and universities for higher studies. Teaching was oral and students remembered and meditated upon what was taught in the Gurukulas. Many of these Gurukulas were named after the sages. Situated in forests, in serene and peaceful surroundings, hundreds of students used to learn together in Gurukulas. During the early period education was imparted by the teacher (Guru/Acharya) to the pupils who gathered around him and came to live in his house as members of his family. This was known as Gurukula system of eduation.

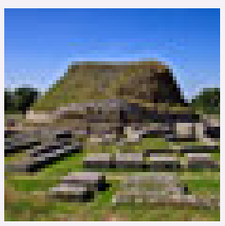
During that period, the gurus and their shishyas (pupils) lived together helping each other in day-to-day life. The main objectives was to have complete learning, leading a disciplined life and realising one's inner potential. Students lived away from their homes for years together till they achieved their goals. The gurukula was also the place where the relationship between the guru and student strengthened with time.

Many monasteries and viharas were set up for monks and nuns to meditate, debate and discuss with the learned for their quest for knowledge during this period. Around these viharas, other educational centres of higher learning developed, which attracted students from China, Korea, Tibet, Burma, Ceylon, Java, Nepal and other distant countries.

Viharas and Universities Buddhist Period



Taxila was an ancient Indian city, which is now in north-western Pakistan. It is an important archaeological site and the UNESCO declared it as a world heritage site in 1980. Its fame rested on the university where Chanakya is said to have composed his Arthashastra. Archaeologist Alexander Cunningham discovered its ruins in the mid-19th century.



The Jataka tales, accounts given by Hiuen Tsang and I-Tsing (Chinese scholars), and other sources tell us that kings and society took an active interest in promoting education. Through monasteries and Viharas Buddhist scholars carried out the educational work. As a result, many famous educational centres came into existence. Among the most notable universities that emerged during that period were situated at Taxila, Nalanda, Valabhi, Vikramshila, Odantapuri and Jagaddala. These universities developed in connection with the viharas. Those at Benaras and Kanchi developed in relation with temples and became centres of community life in the places where they were situated. These institutions catered to the needs of advanced level students. Such students joined

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